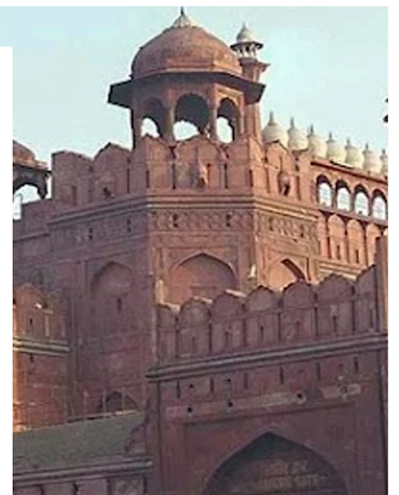
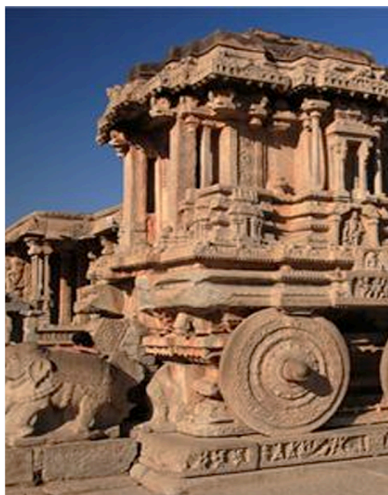


General Knowledge

Medieval History

STUDY NOTES

Sheshah Suri (Interregnum)



Sheshah Suri (Interregnum)



Introduction to the Sur Dynasty

- The **Sur Dynasty** was an **Afghan dynasty** that ruled over North India during the mid-16th century.
- It was founded by **Sher Shah Suri**, who overthrew **Humayun**, the Mughal emperor, in **1540 AD**.
- Although the **dynasty's reign lasted for only 16 years**, it marked a significant era in Indian history with **innovative administrative reforms, infrastructure development, and currency reforms**.
- The Sur Empire is considered a **continuation of the Delhi Sultanate tradition**, bringing a **strong central authority** with a focus on efficient administration.
- Sher Shah Suri, the **most prominent ruler**, implemented policies that became the **foundation of governance for later Mughal emperors**, especially **Akbar**.

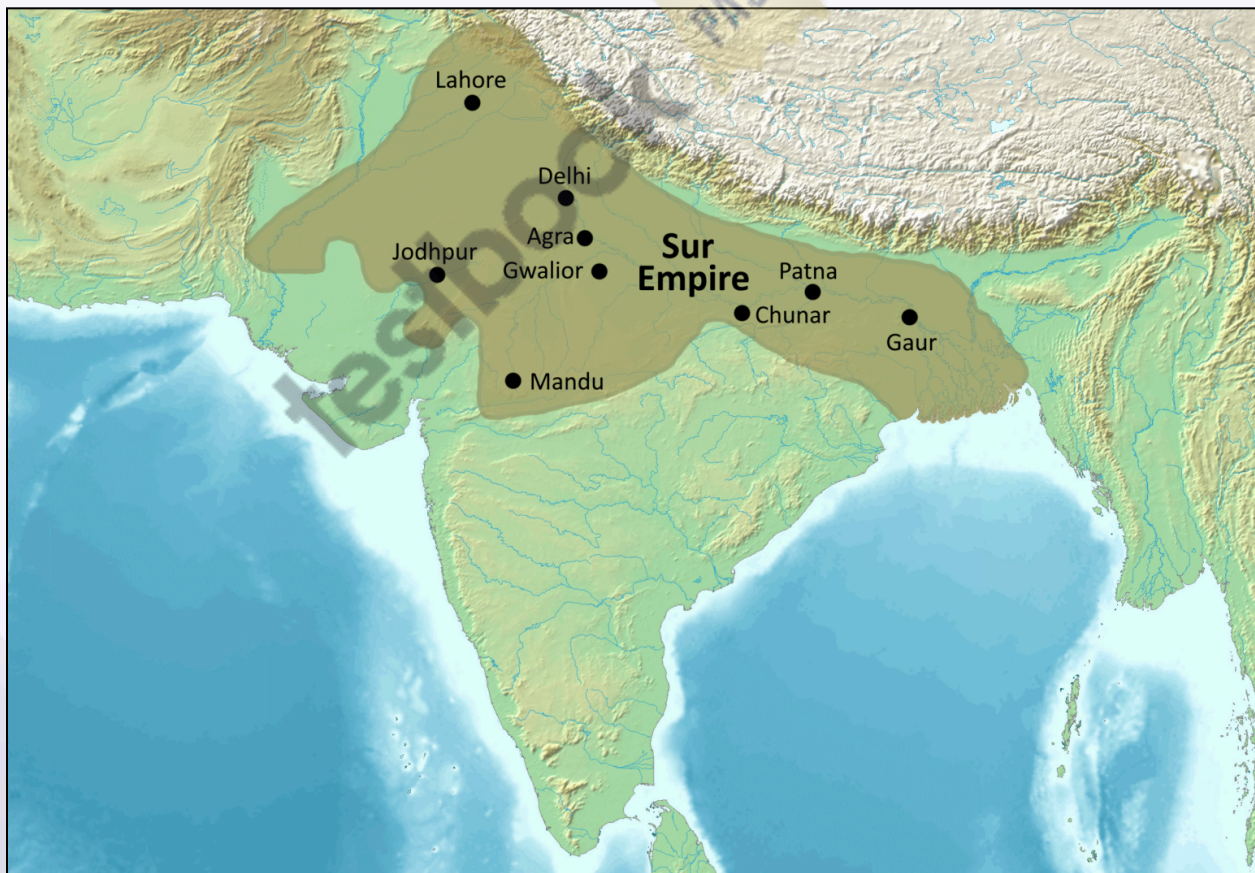
Founding and Establishment

- The **Sur Dynasty** began when **Sher Shah Suri** defeated **Humayun** in the **Battle of Kannauj (1540 AD)**, forcing the Mughals into exile.
- The Sur rulers controlled **vast territories**, extending from **Punjab in the northwest** to **Bengal in the east** and **Malwa in the south**.

- Sher Shah's vision was to **create a unified and well-administered empire**, and his reign focused heavily on **law enforcement, revenue reforms, and public welfare**.

Characteristics of the Sur Dynasty

- **Short yet impactful reign:** The dynasty ruled for a **brief period of 16 years**, but its administrative system greatly influenced later rulers.
- **Administrative brilliance:** Sher Shah introduced **land revenue reforms, military reorganization, and public infrastructure projects** like the **Grand Trunk Road**.
- **Currency reforms:** The introduction of the **silver rupee** became the basis for India's currency system for centuries.
- **Religious tolerance:** Although Sher Shah was a Muslim ruler, he treated **Hindus and Muslims impartially**, recruiting officials from both communities.
- **Decline:** The Sur Dynasty **collapsed soon after Sher Shah's death in 1545 AD** due to **internal conflicts, weak successors, and the return of Humayun**.



Rulers of the Sur Dynasty

Ruler	Reign	Key Features / Contributions
Sher Shah Suri	1540 – 1545 AD	• Founder of the Sur dynasty by overthrowing Humayun. • Introduced land revenue reforms, and a uniform currency system (Rupee). • Built the Grand Trunk Road and other important highways. • Promoted law and order, and ensured safety for merchants and travellers. • Built Rohtas Fort, Sher Shah Suri Masjid, and Sasaram tomb.
Islam Shah Suri	1545 – 1553 AD	• Son of Sher Shah, known for his administrative capability. • Faced tribal feuds and rebellions from his brothers. • Introduced strict discipline in the army and strengthened the administration. • His death resulted in civil war and weakened the dynasty.
Firoz Shah Suri	1553 AD	• Inexperienced successor, ruled for a brief period. • Deposed and executed by Sher Shah's nephew Muhammad Adil Shah.
Muhammad Adil Shah	1553 – 1555 AD	• Deposed Firoz Shah and took the throne. • Faced internal strife and lost control over the administration. • Struggled to maintain control against rising Afghan factions and Mughal resurgence.

Ibrahim Shah Suri	1555 AD	- Declared himself king but ruled for a very short time. - Involved in internal conflicts with other contenders for the throne.
Sikandar Shah Suri	1555 – 1556 AD	- Attempted to resist Humayun's return to power. - Defeated in 1556 AD by the Mughals in the Battle of Sirhind, leading to the final collapse of the Sur dynasty.

Sher Shah Suri

Introduction

- Sher Shah Suri** (1540–1545 AD) was the **founder of the Sur dynasty** and is known for his **administrative genius** and **military prowess**.
- His **original name** was **Farid Khan**. He earned the title **Sher Khan** for his bravery when he killed a **tiger (sher)** single-handedly.
- Sher Shah dethroned **Humayun** in **1540 AD**, becoming the **ruler of North India** and re-establishing the **Afghan Empire** that had been previously lost to the Mughals.
- Despite ruling for only **five years**, his reforms left a lasting impact on Indian governance, influencing both **Akbar's administration** and the **British colonial system**.

Early Life and Rise to Power

- Sher Shah was born in **Sasaram, Bihar**, to a **noble Afghan family**.
- He gained administrative experience by managing his **father's jagir (land grant)** and prospered through his efficiency.
- Over time, he emerged as a **skilled warrior** and **strategist**, earning positions of trust under local rulers.
- Sher Shah first became prominent by **defeating the Lohani chiefs** of Bihar and taking control of the region.
- In a series of encounters, he defeated **Mohammad Shah of Bengal** and forced him to **seek refuge with Humayun**.

Polity and Military Conquests

- Sher Shah defeated the **combined forces of the Lohani chiefs of Bihar and Mohammad Shah of Bengal** at **Surajgarh**, bringing **Bihar under his control**.
- He **captured Gaur**, the capital of Bengal, forcing **Mohammad Shah to seek refuge with Humayun**.
- **Encounters with Humayun:**
 1. **Fort of Chunar (1538):** Sher Shah strategically surrendered.
 2. **Battle of Chausa (1539):** Sher Shah defeated Humayun.
 3. **Battle of Kannauj (1540):** Sher Shah's decisive victory forced **Humayun into exile**.
- Sher Shah's victories gave him control over **Delhi, Agra, Sambhal, and Gwalior**, effectively ending **Mughal rule for 15 years**.
- His empire spanned from **Punjab to Bengal** and **Malwa to Sind**, bringing large parts of India under his control.
- Sher Shah also conquered **Rajasthan** and **Malwa** and aimed to unify India under a **centralized administration**.

Administrative Reforms

- Sher Shah Suri introduced **effective governance systems** that were later adopted by **Akbar and the British**.
- He divided his empire into **47 sarkars (districts)**, which were further divided into **parganas (sub-districts)**.
- **Key administrative officers:**
 - **Chief Shiqdar:** Law and order.
 - **Chief Munsif:** Judge and revenue collection.
 - **Amin:** Land revenue official.
 - **Fotedar:** Treasurer.
 - **Karkun:** Accountant.
- Sher Shah ensured **transparent land revenue administration** by measuring holdings and classifying land into **good, bad, and middling**.
- **Land revenue** was set at **one-third of the produce**, payable in **cash or kind**.
- Peasants were issued **title deeds (patta)** and signed **agreements (kabuliyat)**, ensuring their **rights and responsibilities** were protected.

Military Reforms

- Sher Shah reformed the military system by adopting the **branding of horses (dagh)** and **maintaining soldier records (chehra)**, borrowed from **Alauddin Khalji**.
- He maintained **law and order strictly**, ensuring the safety of **merchants and traders**.
- Sher Shah established **horse posts (mail system)** to improve **communication** and **governance efficiency**.

Economic Reforms and Trade

- Sher Shah introduced **uniform currency**, with the **silver rupee** and **copper dam** becoming the standard currency.
- The **silver rupee** remained the foundation of the Indian currency system for centuries.
- **Custom duties** were introduced, and trade routes were expanded to boost **commerce**.
- He **restored the Grand Trunk Road** (from Chittagong to Kabul), planting trees and building inns (sarais) along the route for **traveller welfare**.
- He also built highways connecting **Agra, Burhanpur, Jodhpur, Chittor, and Lahore to Multan**, facilitating trade and troop movement.

Religion and Governance

- Sher Shah treated **Hindus and Muslims equally** and recruited **Hindus into administrative and military posts**.
- **Jizya (tax on non-Muslims)** was continued, but Sher Shah aimed to reconcile **Hindus and Muslims** under his rule.
- He administered **justice impartially** and closely monitored the conduct of judicial officers.
- Sher Shah was mindful of the **welfare of the peasantry**, ensuring **justice and fair treatment**.

Art and Architecture

- Sher Shah was a **patron of architecture**, blending **Indo-Islamic styles**.
- He built several **mosques, forts, and inns**, including the **Grand Trunk Road**.
- Notable structures:

- **Rohtas Fort** in Punjab.
- **Sher Shah Suri Masjid** in Patna.
- **Qila-i-Kuhna Mosque** at Purana Qila, Delhi.
- His **mausoleum** in **Sasaram, Bihar**, is a masterpiece of Indo-Islamic architecture.

Cultural and Literary Contributions

- **Malik Muhammad Jayasi** wrote the epic **Padmavat** during Sher Shah's reign.
- Sher Shah encouraged **literary pursuits** but focused more on **administration and military strength** than cultural patronage.

Legacy and Impact

- Sher Shah ruled for only **five years**, but his reforms became the foundation for **Akbar's administration** and **British governance**.
- **Humayun** referred to Sher Shah as "**Ustad-i-Badshahan**" (**Teacher of Kings**) in recognition of his **administrative genius**.
- The **currency system** introduced by Sher Shah lasted for centuries, and his **Grand Trunk Road** remains a vital route in modern India.
- His reign proved that **strong central authority** could ensure **economic prosperity** and **law and order** across vast regions.

Reasons for Decline of the Sur Dynasty

- Sher Shah was **fatally injured during a gunpowder blast** in the siege of **Kalinjar Fort** and died in **1545 AD**.
- His **successors** lacked his administrative and military prowess, leading to the quick decline of the Sur dynasty.
- **Islam Shah**, Sher Shah's son, was capable but faced **rebellions from brothers and Afghan tribal feuds**, limiting his ability to govern effectively.
- After **Islam Shah died in 1553**, a **civil war** among his successors further weakened the dynasty.
- The Sur rulers **failed to maintain peasant welfare and revenue collection**, leading to discontent among the population.

- The **disunity among Afghan nobility** prevented the dynasty from sustaining its power.
- **Humayun** took advantage of the Sur dynasty's weakness and **recaptured Delhi and Agra** in **1555 AD**, restoring **Mughal rule** in India.

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